

Day 1 — Drafting Technical PRDs from Customer Requirements

Activity packet for participant triads. Today's job: take your triad's top Week-2 feature concept and start the PRD you'll ship Friday — context, problem, goals, scope, and a solution sketch crisp enough for an engineer to imagine the shape.

Where we are in the week

Week 3 is the mini-capstone. Triads carry their Week-2 strategy package and pick **one feature concept** to PRD this week. By Friday, that PRD ships, peer-reviewed.

Today produces sections 1–5 of the PRD. AC come Day 2. NFRs come Day 3. The integrated assembly happens Day 4. Reviews happen Day 5.

The non-AI rule (reminder)

This week is the discipline of producing a defensible written artifact without a generative tool. AI is off until Week 4. What's allowed: spell-check, dictionary, transcripts, your Week-1 and Week-2 artifacts.

The PRD template (today's reference; printed and on the wall)

```
# PRD — <Feature name>
**Author triad:** <names> | **Date:** <date> | **Status:** Draft

## 1. Context
## 2. Problem
## 3. Goals & non-goals
## 4. Scope (in / out)
## 5. Solution sketch
## 6. Acceptance Criteria [Day 2]
## 7. Non-Functional Requirements [Day 3]
## 8. Metrics & validation [Day 4]
## 9. Risks & open questions [Day 4]
## 10. Dependencies [Day 4]
## 11. Out-of-scope follow-ups [Day 4]
```

Activity 1 — Pick the One Feature

Format: Triad • 35 min • Block 1

Purpose

Force the triad to commit to **one** feature concept from Week 2 and articulate why that one. Many triads will want to keep all three — the discipline of choosing is the work.

Setup

Each triad needs their three Week-2 feature cards, the four-dimension scoring sheet, and a blank memo template. No AI tools.

Triad protocol

1. **Re-read the 3 feature cards aloud** (5 min)
2. **Score each on 4 dimensions** (10 min). 1–5 each:
 - **Friction severity** — how big is the pain it addresses?
 - **Metric movability** — how confident are we it'll move the metric in 30 days?
 - **Build feasibility** — how achievable in one quarter?
 - **Learning value** — what do we learn even if it doesn't ship?
3. **Pick one** (10 min). Highest total score is the default; if scores tie, the triad must argue.
4. **Write the "Why this one" memo** (10 min). Two paragraphs:
 - Paragraph 1: Why this feature, in user terms
 - Paragraph 2: Why this feature, in business / strategy terms

Output

A single feature locked in, with a "Why this one" memo. The memo seeds Section 1 (Context).

Activity 2 — Section 1 (Context) and Section 2 (Problem)

Format: Triad • 40 min • Block 2

Purpose

Write the two sections that give the engineer who reads the PRD enough to **care** about the work before they read what to build.

Setup

Each triad needs Week-1 interview notes and the Week-2 journey map within arm's reach. Print or pin the PRD template. No AI.

Section 1: Context (½ page max)

What this section answers:

- Why this work? (Customer signal — pull from Week-1 interviews/tickets)
- Why now? (Strategic fit — pull from Week-2 NS / Tier Sheet)
- What changed? (If anything triggered the urgency)

What this section avoids:

- **✗** "Customers are asking for it" (vague)
- **✗** Marketing language ("delight users")
- **✗** Restating the company strategy from scratch

Section 2: Problem (½ to ¾ page)

What this section answers:

- The user's **job-to-be-done** (verb-based, in their language)
- The **friction they hit today** (specific, observed)
- Why **today's workarounds are inadequate**

Tie explicitly to the **Week-2 journey map**. Reference the friction stars.

Triad protocol

1. **Each member drafts §1 alone** (10 min). Three drafts.
2. **Pick the strongest** (10 min). Combine if needed.
3. **Each member drafts §2 alone** (10 min).
4. **Pick the strongest, combine, edit** (10 min).

What "good" looks like

- Section 1 fits on half a page.
- Section 2 quotes a real customer (from Week-1 interviews) at least once.
- The reader leaves §2 knowing whose Wednesday afternoon will improve.

Deliverable

Drafted §1 (Context) and §2 (Problem) appended to the triad's PRD, with at least one verbatim customer quote in §2.

Activity 3 — Section 3 (Goals & Non-goals) and Section 4 (Scope)

Format: Triad • 40 min • Block 3

Purpose

Define what success means **in user terms** and bound what will and won't ship in this iteration. Non-goals and out-of-scope items are the most under-valued sections of any PRD.

Setup

Each triad needs their Week-2 Tier Sheet (for metric ties) and the §§1–2 they just drafted. Whiteboard or worksheet for the scope table.

Section 3: Goals & non-goals

Goals (3–5 max):

- Each goal is a **user outcome**, not a feature
- Each goal is **observable** within 30 days of ship
- ❌ "Ship the dashboard" → ✅ "Dispatchers see open work without hunting"

Non-goals (2–4):

- What you explicitly will *not* do
- Often the most valuable section — pre-empts scope creep
- ❌ Skip this section → ✅ "We will not redesign the navigation bar"

Section 4: Scope (in / out)

A two-column table:

IN SCOPE	OUT OF SCOPE (THIS ITERATION)
Mobile flow	Tablet layout
Online + offline draft	Offline-first sync
English only	Spanish localization

Out-of-scope is the **negotiation tool** — it tells stakeholders "I see what you might also want; here's why this iteration doesn't include it."

Triad protocol

1. **Draft 5 candidate goals** (10 min). Cull to 3.
2. **Draft 3 candidate non-goals** (10 min). Cull to 2.
3. **Draft scope table** (15 min). Force the right column.
4. **Sanity check** (5 min). Does each goal tie to a friction star or metric?

Deliverable

§3 (Goals & non-goals) and §4 (Scope in/out table) appended to the PRD, each goal tied to a Tier Sheet metric.

Activity 4 — Section 5 (Solution Sketch)

Format: Triad • 45 min + Wrap • Block 4

Purpose

Describe the solution **just enough** for an engineer to imagine its shape — not so much that you've designed it for them. This is the most-mis-written section in real-world PRDs.

Setup

Each triad needs blank paper for sketches, the §§1–4 they just drafted, and the §5 inclusion/exclusion checklist. No AI.

What goes in §5

- The **user-visible flow**: 4–8 steps from the user's perspective
- The **key surfaces** affected (which screens, which surfaces)
- The **hard interactions** with other systems (other products, APIs, third parties — name them)
- A **happy path** narrative (one paragraph; what a successful run looks like)
- Optional: 1–2 simple sketches or wireframes (allowed; encouraged for clarity)

What does NOT go in §5

- Database schema decisions
- Specific API contracts
- Class names, framework choices, library picks
- Pixel-level layout

The "engineer's first three questions" test

After writing §5, ask: what are the **first three questions** an engineer would ask after reading this? If those questions are about implementation choice, you've over-specified. If they're about user behavior or scope, you've under-specified.

Triad protocol

1. **Sketch the flow** (15 min). On paper. 4–8 steps.
2. **Write the happy-path paragraph** (10 min).
3. **List the hard interactions** (10 min).
4. **The three-questions test** (10 min). Each member proposes 3 engineer questions; flag any that signal over- or under-specification.

Deliverable

§5 (Solution sketch) appended to the PRD: flow steps, hard-interactions list, happy-path paragraph, and the triad's three-questions diagnosis.

Wrap (last 15 min)

Each triad shares with the room:

- The feature name
- One sentence of context
- One sentence of problem
- The top goal
- The top non-goal

This **two-minute share** is intentional. It catches generic feature concepts before the triad invests another 3 days drafting.

End-of-day checkpoint

Each triad leaves the day with a draft PRD containing:

- ✓ Title + author + date + status
- ✓ Section 1 (Context)
- ✓ Section 2 (Problem)
- ✓ Section 3 (Goals & non-goals)
- ✓ Section 4 (Scope in / out)
- ✓ Section 5 (Solution sketch)
- ✓ "Why this one" memo (informal — feeds §1 if useful)